

EDEN'S TABLE · SPROUTS STORYBOOK

Introductory Story

Meet the Family

Spotlight: The Eden's Herb: Lavender

Who is at Vovo's table?

No one had said grace yet, and Bear had already made his decision about the cornbread.

He was a chocolate goldendoodle roughly the size of a small piece of furniture, and he had stationed himself at the corner of the table where the cornbread sat cooling in its cast-iron pan, wearing the long-suffering expression of a dog who has never once in his life been fed from the table and is certain, any minute now, that today will be the day it changes. His chin was not on the table. His chin hovered one respectful inch above the table, which Bear believed was a different thing entirely. The rules, apparently, did not.

This was the homestead — Vovó and PopPop's place, a white farmhouse at the end of a gravel road outside Clarksville, Tennessee, with a garden out back that was bigger than the house and twice as busy. The whole family came on Sundays. They had come on Sundays for longer than the youngest of them had been alive, which meant that to Gracie, Sundays at the homestead were simply what the world was made of, the same as trees and weather.

Vovó — which means “grandma” in Portuguese, the language her own mother had carried up from Brazil and pressed into her like a seed — was at the stove, barefoot, the way she was nearly always barefoot, moving between three pots with the unbothered authority of a small woman who had cooked this same meal ten thousand times and could do it in the dark if the power ever had the nerve to go out. There was silver in her hair she had never once considered covering, and she ran her kitchen the way some people run a country. The kitchen, for its part, cooperated. Things were where Vovó's hand expected them to be. They had learned.

She had grown up in two languages and cooked in a third that nobody could name, and when she was warm, or when she wanted you to truly listen, she slipped into the Portuguese her mother had given her — *minha filha*, my girl; *meu amor*, my love.

"Sit," she said — to no one in particular, and therefore to everyone — and the family began, slowly, to sit.

PopPop was already sitting. PopPop was usually already sitting. He had a gift for arriving at the exact center of a room and then becoming, very gently, furniture: present, warm, and in no hurry to prove either. He was a tall Black man gone comfortable in the middle, with long grey dreadlocks he had been growing since before any of the grandchildren were born, and he watched the cornbread situation developing at the corner of the table with the calm of a man who had seen this exact crime attempted many times.

"Easy, Booboo," he said to Gracie, who had her elbow on the table and her eyes locked on the pan. "Good things and cornbread both come to the ones who wait."

"I've been waiting," Gracie said.

"Mm," said PopPop. "Not the same as patient, but it's a start."

Then the door banged, because the door always banged when the rest of them arrived, and the kitchen filled up the way it did every Sunday — all at once, loudly, like weather coming in off a field.

Levi came in first, because Levi came into most rooms first. He was Vovó and PopPop's son, built like his father and quick like his mother, a man who walked fast and talked faster and had opinions the way other people have weather: constantly, and out loud. He kissed Vovó on the top of her head without slowing down, which was the only speed at which Levi did anything tender, and dropped into the chair beside PopPop. "Smells good, Mom." "It is good," said Vovó. "I made it." Levi laughed — he laughed more easily than people expected, the ones who only knew him for the first ten minutes — and he loved hard and argued harder and brought nearly everything, eventually, back around to the Word. Death and life, he liked to say, tapping the table twice, are in the power of the tongue. He believed it completely. He was also still learning to live it, which was a different and slower project.

Ruthie came in behind him, and the room softened half a degree around her without anyone deciding to let it. She was Levi's wife, Alabama-raised, fair and blonde and blue-eyed, with the kind of good manners that were less about politeness than about a deep unwillingness to take up more room than she had been given. She set a pie on the counter, touched Vovo's shoulder in greeting, and slid into her seat. Ruthie had grown up in a house where health was a thing that happened to you, usually badly and usually without warning, and where the answer to most of it was fear and a waiting room. She had married into a family that thought about all of it completely differently, and she was somewhere in the long middle of changing her mind — not there yet, not nowhere, just on the road. She asked more questions than she answered. Her questions, as it turned out, were usually the ones everyone else was too busy or too certain to ask.

"BIRTHDAY GIRL," announced Manny from the doorway, to Evie, whose birthday it was not.

Manny was seventeen and built like a question mark that had decided to be cheerful about it: tall, lanky, all elbows and warmth, with a smile that arrived a half-second before the rest of him did. He was the oldest of the three and the least likely ever to stop being the baby of any room he walked into. He remembered everybody's birthday, including several that did not exist, and he wanted, more than almost anything, to be a youth minister someday — which surprised no one who had watched him spend twenty minutes making a checkout clerk feel like the most important person in Tennessee. "It's not my birthday," Evie said. "It's somebody's birthday somewhere," said Manny, folding himself into his chair, "and I like to stay ready." He bumped Gracie's shoulder with his on the way down. Gracie bumped him back harder, on principle.

Manny had been diagnosed with diabetes just the year before, at sixteen — the kind that arrives without warning and does not leave. It had been a hard year, harder than he let most people see; he was still learning the new rules his own body had handed him, and the whole family was learning them alongside him. It had not made him less himself. If anything, it had made him the most attentive person at the table to how a body actually felt from the inside. But that is a longer story, and it belongs to a later one.

Evie had taken the seat in the corner, which was her favorite seat, because from the corner you could see everyone and no one could quite see all of you at once. She was twelve, and soft-spoken, and soft in nearly every other way too — a girl who loved the color pink without apology and apologized for almost everything else, often for things that were in no way her fault. She felt what other people felt a half-step before they felt it, caught their moods the way you catch a cold, and spent a great deal of quiet energy making sure that no one at any table was ever, even slightly, upset. She did not yet know this was a gift. She mostly experienced it as weather she could not get out of. "I like your braid," she said softly to Ruthie, because she had noticed Ruthie looked tired, and was trying to hand her something good.

And Gracie — Gracie was six, and Gracie was the one with her elbow already on the table and her whole attention already on the cornbread, conducting, at that exact moment, the same delicate negotiation Bear was conducting, with roughly the same odds. She was Vovó's baby and Vovó's project both, a small person made almost entirely of opinions and loyalty. She said what she thought the instant she thought it, valued the truth a good deal more than she valued anybody's feelings about the truth, and held a grudge the way a safe holds money — securely, with no plans to give it back. She also went first through any door she believed one of her people was on the wrong side of. She poked at her brother and her sister without mercy and would have walked through a wall for either of them, and saw no contradiction in this whatsoever.

"Are we eating," Gracie said, "or are we just looking at it."

"We are saying grace," said Vovó, sitting down at last, "and you are going to wait, minha filha, the way the cornbread waited for you."

Gracie folded her arms. "Fine."

They held hands around the table to pray, which was, with this family, a logistical event.

PopPop prayed. He always prayed, slow and unhurried, the same way he did everything — thanking God for the food, and for the hands that grew it, and for the rain that had finally come after making them ask twice. And somewhere in the middle of it, in the warm dark behind everyone's closed eyes, Bear made his move.

It was, by Bear's standards, a masterpiece. He did not lunge; he understood that lunging was for amateurs. He simply leaned — slowly, geologically — until his nose reached the lip of the cast-iron pan, and then attempted to remove one entire square of cornbread with the delicacy of a surgeon and the discretion of a marching band. The pan, which weighed considerably more than Bear had budgeted for, slid. It caught the handle of a spoon. The spoon flipped a respectable arc of green beans into the air, the pan rang against the table like a bell calling a very small church to order, and every head at the table came up at once.

Bear stood frozen with half a square of cornbread in his mouth and a look of profound theological surprise, as though he too could not account for what had happened, as though the cornbread had leapt.

For one held breath nobody moved. Then Manny lost it, and once Manny was gone the whole table went with him — even Levi, even Gracie, who held out longest as a matter of dignity before folding. "Amen," said PopPop, who had never once stopped, and had prayed clean through the entire disaster with his eyes shut and a small smile he did not bother to hide. "Lord knows we needed the laugh too."

The meal, once it got going, got going the way the family did everything — all at once and overlapping, three conversations and one dog, plates passed the wrong direction, somebody's elbow always in somebody's space. Nearly all of it had come out of the garden behind the house. The greens, the tomatoes, the herbs Vovó had folded into the chicken without announcing them. Ruthie noticed, the way she noticed most things without saying so, that she could not have named half of what she was eating, and that everyone else at the table could.

"How do you know all of it?" she asked Vovó, quietly, between passing dishes. "Every plant out there. What it's for. You never look anything up."

Vovó considered the question with the seriousness she gave to questions that were really about something else. "The same way you know your children's faces," she said. "Somebody put them in front of you, every day, until you did." She did not explain it further than that. She went back to her plate, and let the answer sit where it had landed.

After — while the grown-ups lingered over coffee and Levi got louder and PopPop got quieter, which was their oldest and most comfortable arrangement — Gracie went out to the garden, because the garden was where you went.

It was not a tidy garden. It was a working one: rows and tangles and a fat green riot of things Gracie could only half name. Lavender going gray-purple along the path. Mint staging its yearly invasion of the tomatoes. Something tall and yellow the bees took very seriously. Vovó came out, as she always eventually came out, and walked the rows the way she walked her kitchen — knowing where everything was without looking for it.

"Did you plant all this?" Gracie asked. She asked it most Sundays, and she knew the answer.

"I planted some of it," Vovó said. "My mother planted some of it, in her garden, before mine. And her mother before her." She bent and pulled a weed without appearing to have looked for it. "Somebody put all of this here a long, long time before any of us. We are only keeping it going. Tending it. Watching it. Handing it down."

Evie had drifted out behind them, and Ruthie behind Evie, drying her hands on a towel she had carried outside without meaning to. She stopped at the edge of the garden where it met the grass and watched her two girls follow the small barefoot woman down the rows, and something in her face was caught halfway between longing and arithmetic — as if she were trying to work out how a person learns a thing like this, and whether it was already too late to begin.

Vovó crouched down to Gracie's height, one hand on her knee. "You want to know the most amazing thing God ever made?" she asked.

Gracie, who had several candidates, weighed them. "Dinosaurs," she offered.

"Close," said Vovó, which made Gracie grin in spite of herself. "No. I think it is you." She tapped Gracie once, lightly, in the center of her chest. "He made you on purpose, every single piece of you. And before you were ever born, He wrote into you everything your body would need to know to take care of itself. You never taught your blood how to close a cut. You never taught your nose what it likes. It is all already in there. Fearfully. Wonderfully. On purpose."

Gracie looked down at her own chest as though she might be able to see in.

"How do you know that?" she asked.

"Because somebody taught me," Vovó said. "The same way I am going to teach you." She straightened, slowly, one hand pushing off her knee. "All year. A little at a time. Out here, and in there." She tipped her head toward the kitchen, glowing yellow now in the early evening, the men's laughter rolling out through the screen. "The garden and the table. That is the whole school."

At the edge of the grass, Ruthie said it before she could stop herself — quietly, mostly to herself. "I wish I'd grown up knowing any of this."

Vovó did not turn around. "You did not have to grow up with it," she said, "to grow into it." And that was as close to a promise as anyone made that evening — not loud, not underlined, just laid down in the dirt between the lavender and the tomatoes, like a seed somebody trusted to come up on its own.

The sun was dropping behind the tree line. Bear had located the single best patch of late light in the yard and collapsed into it as though the day had asked far too much of him. Inside, somebody started the dishes. And Gracie stood in the middle of a garden her great-great-grandmother had started, in a small fierce body that had been quietly healing her, her whole life, without ever once being asked — and felt, for just a second, before she would have denied it to anyone, the enormous and ordinary wonder of being a person who had been thought of in advance.

She had a whole year of Sundays ahead of her. She did not yet know what was in them.

She was about to find out.